and when the band decided where to pitch camp, where to go hunting or how to handle a conflict with another band, everyone could take part in the conversation and dispute one another. Bands usually belonged to a larger tribe that included hundreds or even thousands of people. But when important choices affecting the whole tribe had to be made, such as whether to go to war, tribes were usually still small enough for a large percentage of their members to gather in one place and converse.[15]

While bands and tribes sometimes had dominant leaders, these tended to exercise only limited authority. Leaders had no standing armies, police forces or governmental bureaucracies at their disposal, so they couldn't just impose their will by force.[16] Leaders also found it difficult to control the economic basis of people's lives. In modern times, dictators like Vladimir Putin and Saddam Hussein have often based their political power on monopolising economic assets like oil wells.[17] In medieval and classical antiquity, Chinese emperors, Greek tyrants and Egyptian pharaohs dominated society by controlling granaries, silver mines and irrigation canals. In contrast, in a hunter-gatherer economy such centralised economic control was possible only under special circumstances. For example, along the northwestern coast of North America some hunter-gatherer economies relied on catching and preserving large numbers of salmon. Since salmon runs peaked for a few weeks in specific creeks and rivers, a powerful chief could monopolise this asset.[18]

But this was exceptional. Most hunter-gatherer economies were far more diversified. One leader, even supported by a few allies, could not corral the savannah and prevent people from gathering plants and hunting animals there. If all else failed, hunter-gatherers could therefore vote with their feet. They had few possessions, and their most important assets were their personal skills and personal friends. If a chief turned dictatorial, people could just walk away.[19]

Even when hunter-gatherers did end up ruled by a domineering chief, as happened among the salmon-fishing people of northwestern America, at least that chief was accessible. He didn't live in a faraway fortress surrounded by an unfathomable bureaucracy and a cordon of armed guards. If you wanted to voice a complaint or a suggestion, you could usually get within earshot of him. The chief couldn't control public opinion, nor could he shut himself off from it. In other words, there was no way for a chief to